



HORMONAL BIRTH CONTROL

What Is Hormonal Birth Control?

Hormonal contraceptives prevent pregnancy by using synthetic hormones such as progestin alone or a combination of estrogen and progestin. These are available in various forms, including oral pills, transdermal patches, and vaginal rings

How Hormonal Methods Work

Combined hormonal contraceptives primarily work by suppressing ovulation so no egg is released. They also thicken cervical mucus to make it harder for sperm to reach an egg, and thin the uterine lining to discourage implantation.

Overview of Methods

- Combined oral contraceptive pill (COC): Taken daily at the same time. With perfect use, over 99% effective. With typical use, about 91% effective.
- Progestin-only pill (mini-pill): Suitable for people who cannot use estrogen (e.g., those who smoke or have certain medical conditions). Must be taken at the same time each day.
- Transdermal patch: Applied to the skin and changed weekly for three weeks, with a patchfree week. Contains estrogen and progestin.
- Vaginal ring (NuvaRing): A flexible ring inserted into the vagina for three weeks, then removed for one week. Self-administered.

Possible Benefits Beyond Contraception

- Reduces menstrual cramps and lightens periods
- May improve acne
- Can help manage symptoms of endometriosis and PCOS
- Reduces risk of ovarian and endometrial cancer with long-term use

Important Considerations

- Does not protect against sexually transmitted infections (STIs).
- May cause side effects including nausea, breast tenderness, mood changes, and headaches.
- Not recommended for those who smoke and are over 35 (combined methods).
- Certain medications can reduce effectiveness, so you should always inform your provider about everything you are taking
- Fertility typically returns quickly after stopping.

Key Takeaway

Hormonal birth control is a highly effective, flexible option for preventing pregnancy and managing certain health conditions. The right method depends on individual health history, lifestyle, and preferences.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Combined hormonal birth control: Pill, patch, and ring.

Trussell, J. (2011). Contraceptive failure in the United States. Office on Women's Health. (2021). Birth control methods.